

# Local SEO and Google Business Profile

*One dropdown, the primary category, is the strongest single lever in local SEO.*

## Bottom line

Local is judged across three surfaces now: the map pack, local organic results, and AI recommendations. Google Business Profile signals and reviews together carry roughly **half** the reported map pack weighting, and **46% of all Google searches carry local intent**. If you have a physical location or a service area, this section outranks most of Tier 3 in priority.

## The three surfaces

Local visibility is no longer one ranking.

**The map pack.** The three-result block with a map. Driven overwhelmingly by GBP signals, reviews and proximity.

**Local organic.** Standard blue links for local-intent queries. Driven by normal SEO plus local relevance signals.

**AI recommendations.** ChatGPT, Perplexity and AI Overviews recommending businesses by name. Increasingly driven by review volume, sentiment and structured local data.

You can rank in one and be invisible in the others. Check all three separately.

## Reported map pack weighting

| Signal group                                                         | Weight     |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| <b>Google Business Profile</b> (categories, completeness, freshness) | <b>32%</b> |
| <b>Reviews</b> (volume, velocity, sentiment)                         | <b>20%</b> |
| <b>On-page</b> (NAP, local keywords, authority)                      | <b>15%</b> |
| <b>Behavioral</b> (CTR, click-to-call, direction requests)           | <b>9%</b>  |
| <b>Links</b> (local backlinks, brand authority)                      | <b>8%</b>  |
| <b>Citations</b> (directory consistency)                             | <b>6%</b>  |

[practitioner, modeled estimates, not disclosed weights]

Read the tier flag carefully. These are practitioner surveys and modeled estimates, not figures Google has published. They are directionally consistent across sources and useful for prioritization, and they are not facts.

**The directional takeaway holds regardless of the exact percentages: GBP plus reviews is roughly half the game, and citations are the smallest slice.** That ordering is the opposite of how most local SEO packages are sold, which lead with bulk citation submissions.

## Google Business Profile

**The primary category is the strongest individual signal in local SEO.** Pick the most specific match available. "Personal Injury Attorney" beats "Lawyer". "Italian Restaurant" beats "Restaurant". [practitioner]

This is one dropdown. It takes thirty seconds to change and it outranks weeks of other work. Check it first, on every local audit, every time.

Secondary categories should be genuinely applicable, not a keyword dump.

**The rest of the profile:**

- **Complete every field.** Hours, attributes, service areas, description, products, services. Completeness is part of the 32%.
- **Post 1 to 3 Google Posts weekly.** These now surface in AI Overview citations, which makes a formerly low-value feature worth doing. [practitioner]
- **Seed 8 to 12 Q&A entries** covering pricing, service areas, parking, process, and the questions you actually get asked. You can ask and answer your own questions, and this feeds answer engines directly. [practitioner]
- **Photos: 10 to 25 minimum,** refreshed periodically.

### An honesty flag on a number you will hear quoted

the claim that profiles with **100+ photos get 520% more calls** traces to vendor research citing Google, not to any Google publication. Treat it as directional at best. The defensible version is that photo volume correlates with engagement. The 10 to 25 minimum is the safe recommendation, and quoting the 520% figure to a client is exactly the kind of thing that damages your credibility when someone checks it.

## Reviews

Second-largest weight group at 20%, and the one with the clearest cadence guidance.

- **Target 2 to 4 new reviews per week.** [practitioner]

- **A sustained 5 to 15 per month over six months** is reported to move a business **5 to 10 map pack positions**. [practitioner]
- **Respond within 24 to 48 hours**, to positive and negative alike. [practitioner]

**For the AI surface specifically:** businesses with **50+ reviews in 12 months** are reported **3x more likely** to appear in AI recommendations, and a **4.5+ star rating** roughly doubles citation frequency. [practitioner, single vendor]

Single-vendor claims, so hold them loosely. The underlying logic is sound: models summarizing "best X in Y" have review text as their richest available signal.

**Velocity matters more than total.** Forty reviews acquired steadily over a year reads as a functioning business. Forty acquired in one week reads as a campaign, and review platforms filter aggressively for exactly that pattern.

**Never buy reviews.** Beyond the platform risk, it is the one tactic in this course that is straightforwardly illegal in several jurisdictions.

## NAP and citations

**NAP** is Name, Address, Phone. The requirement is that they are **byte-identical everywhere**.

**Minor discrepancies genuinely suppress rankings.** "St." versus "Street", a suite number present in one listing and absent in another, two different phone numbers. These read as two different businesses. [practitioner]

**Fix in tier order:**

- 1 Tier 1:** Google Business Profile, Bing Places, Apple Maps, Yelp, Facebook
- 2 Aggregators:** Data Axle, Localeze
- 3 Industry directories** relevant to your category

Tooling: BrightLocal, Whitespark, Yext.

Citations are only 6% of the weighting. Get the tier 1 five correct and the aggregators clean, then stop. Bulk directory submission packages are selling you the smallest slice of the pie, and per Section 33 they carry active downside.

## Local landing pages

If you serve multiple locations, each needs its own page. The failure is universal and obvious: **a template with the city name swapped in**.

That is doorway-page behavior and it does not rank. Real local pages need genuinely unique content: local staff, local projects, local case studies, directions and parking, area-specific service details, local testimonials.

**If you cannot write something genuinely different about a location, do not create a page for it.** One strong page covering a region beats twelve thin city pages, and this mirrors the Section 31 conclusion about international versions exactly.

## Schema and speed

**LocalBusiness** schema, plus **Service** and **FAQPage** where applicable, per Section 30.

Pages with FAQ schema are reported **4x more likely to be cited in AI Overviews**.

[practitioner] Note this sits alongside Section 30's finding that FAQ *rich results* sunset in May 2026. The rich result is gone, the markup still feeds answer engines. Keep the markup.

**Mobile load under 2 seconds.** Local search is overwhelmingly mobile and often on a phone network, which makes Section 27 and 28's work directly load-bearing here.

## Do this now

- 1 Open your Google Business Profile and check the primary category.** Is it the most specific accurate option? Change it if not. This is the highest-leverage thirty seconds in the section.
- 2 Complete every empty field.** Hours, attributes, services, description, service areas.
- 3 Add photos to at least 10** if you are below that.
- 4 Write and publish one Google Post.** Then diarize weekly.
- 5 Seed 8 to 12 Q&A entries** from the questions you actually get asked.
- 6 Audit NAP across the tier 1 five.** Google, Bing Places, Apple Maps, Yelp, Facebook. Fix every discrepancy, including punctuation.
- 7 Count your reviews from the last 12 months** and your current average rating. Set a target of 2 to 4 per week and build an actual asking process.
- 8 Respond to every unanswered review,** oldest first.
- 9 Check your LocalBusiness schema** validates per Section 30.
- 10 Search your main local query on a phone** and note whether you appear in the map pack, local organic, and an AI answer. Three separate checks.

## Capstone step

Your capstone site has the most specific accurate primary category set, a fully completed profile with photos and weekly Posts, 8 to 12 seeded Q&A entries, NAP verified identical across the tier 1 five, validated LocalBusiness schema, a review cadence target with a real asking process, and a baseline of visibility across all three local surfaces.

If the capstone has no local component, note that explicitly and move to Section 36. A documented "not applicable" is a legitimate finding, as in Section 31.

## Key takeaways

- The primary category is the strongest single lever in local SEO. Most specific accurate option, checked first, every time.
- GBP plus reviews is roughly half the reported weighting. Citations are 6%, which is the reverse of how local packages are usually sold.
- Review velocity of 2 to 4 per week beats bulk acquisition, and **50+ reviews with a 4.5+ rating** is the reported threshold for AI recommendation visibility.
- NAP must be byte-identical across the tier 1 five. "St." versus "Street" is a real ranking problem, and local pages need genuinely unique content or they should not exist.